

וילך. The last מצוה in the תורה is (31:19) הַשִּׁירָה הַזֹּאת. It's usually translated as "And now, write for yourselves this song." It's specifically referring to האזינו, but we learn the הלכה of writing a ספר תורה, which is called a song to Hashem, from this.

There are two different aspects of this pasuk which have divergent purposes but come to the same conclusion. In פרקי אבות we learn a famous rule (4:5): הַלּוֹמֵד תּוֹרָה עַל מִנָּת לְלַמֵּד, מְסַפֵּיקוֹן בְּיָדוֹ לְלַמֵּד וּלְלַמֵּד. וְהַלּוֹמֵד. על מִנָּת לַעֲשׂוֹת, מְסַפֵּיקוֹן בְּיָדוֹ לְלַמֵּד וּלְלַמֵּד לְשֹׁמֵר וְלַעֲשׂוֹת. One of the עיקר purposes of learning and teaching is to accomplish. We can accomplish things in many ways. We can accomplish by sitting and learning, and we can accomplish by doing מצוות. Learning itself is also a מצוה. What is the point? Listen to this. The ר"א, no less than the ר"א, which the שלחן ערוך and all of our פוסקים come from, writes in פסקי הרא"ש that in his time there were so many ספרי תורה standing in the ארון קודש that they never got used, and he says a better way to fulfill this מצוה, believe it or not, as joyous as we are when we have a new תורה, we make a parade and we're so proud and happy to see a ספר תורה joining the ranks of the ספרי תורה, he says that it's an even greater מצוה to write ספרים of תורה שבעל פה.

When a person sits down and writes ספרים, when a person sits down and writes ספרים and he's learning תורה, when a person sits down and writes ספרים, he's being מקיים this מצוה on an even greater level. How does the ר"א know that? Because the pasuk says וְעַתָּה - and now. Why "and now" - only now? He explains that in משה רבינו's time, when there were very few ספרי תורה, each שבט having only one, then הַשִּׁירָה הַזֹּאת meant the מצוה was to write תורה שבכתב. However, in future דורות when there will be many ספרי תורה, it's much better to write תורה חידושי. That is the עיקר of the מצוה - to write דברי תורה. By doing so, a person can fulfill תורה שבעל פה according to the ר"א.

Now, a completely different take on some aspect of transmitting תורה. This is a fascinating story, the beginning of which all of you will know and recognize, but the end of which most have never heard, as I hadn't either - unless you've learned more than me, which is of course not that difficult. It says in the pasuk (31:28) הַקְהִילוּ אֵלַי אֶת כָּל זָקְנֵי שְׁבִטֵיכֶם וְשִׁטְרֵיכֶם וְאַדְבָּרָה בְּאָזְנֵיהֶם אֶת הַדְּבָרִים הָאֵלֶּה. You have to write the תורה, but I also have to transmit it orally פה אל פה, from my mouth משה says; וְאַדְבָּרָה בְּאָזְנֵיהֶם - and into their ears; וְאַדְבָּרָה בְּאָזְנֵיהֶם - all of these things. What are these things? We generally understand it to mean the תורה, that there are many ways of transmitting תורה: writing, speaking, learning, and doing. But listen to this.

We all know the מעשה with תלמי המלך brought down in עמוד א' מסכת מגילה דף ט' עמוד א', how he gathered 72 זקנים. He wanted to prove or disprove the veracity of תורה. He put them all into separate compartments. We all know this story, and he went over to each one individually and said, "I want you to translate the תורה of your teacher משה". We know that the מדרש says that הקדוש ברוך הוא put into the heart of each and every one of them the עצה and they all made the same changes, because they had to change some of the words so that there shouldn't be any misrepresentation, but they all changed it in exactly the same way, a tremendous נס. As an aside, we know that this is a black day in history when the תורה was translated because it was not meant to be translated, but leaving that aside for the moment; this was a tremendous נס, that they all made exactly the same changes.

The brings the התורה [which is not the same ש"ך as the ש"ך in the שלחן ערוך] in our פרשה, that which was going to happen to תלמי המלך and the זקנים, that they would have to translate the תורה against their will and would need to make changes so there shouldn't be a לעז, there shouldn't be a rumor חס ושלום about the veracity of the תורה. So משה רבינו gathered together 72 זקנים, and he told them in their ears all of these changes, that these are the changes that would have to be made if the תורה is going to be translated. He instructed them to pass it down in every דור, each דור after that time, so that the זקנים would transmit these שינויים to the next generation, until the time of תלמי המלך. That way there could not be any accusation against the תורה.



According to the ש"ך, these 72 זקנים did not make up these changes by themselves. We say הקדוש ברוך הוא put it into their mind, but according to the ש"ך, it was a מסורה from משה רבינו of how to transmit the תורה and how to perpetuate the truth of the תורה by באַזניקם. This goes back to our pasuk of כְּתַבּוּ לָכֶם אֶת הַשִּׁירָה הַזֹּאת. We are keeping the תורה eternally that no matter what happens to it, no matter what happens in history, there will not be any לעז against it. They may not agree with us, they may burn the תורה, but no one has ever accused us of falsifying the תורה. That's what this pasuk is saying with באַזניקם, they are not to change this or to transmit this secret to anyone else but only to the זקנים of each דור so that they would have the genuine changes that משה רבינו instructed them to make.

Bottom line, we all have to do our part to continue transmitting both תורה שבכתב and תורה שבעל פה. No matter what we do, in whatever modality we have, whether it's writing it on white stones or doing it through a podcast, we're being מצוה the מקיים. In that זכות, all our children and אייניקלעך will continue that עד ביאת גואל צדק.

